

163 Lydia

The businesswoman by the river "whose heart the Lord opened."

Lydia was a trader in purple cloth from the city of Thyatira, living in Philippi when Paul first crossed into Europe. She already worshipped the God of Israel. One sabbath she was with a group of women praying by a river outside the city when Paul and his companions sat down and spoke to them. As she listened, the Lord opened her heart. She and her household were baptized, and she insisted that the missionaries stay in her home. Later the believers gathered at her house. She is the first convert Acts records in Europe, and her faith moved quickly from hearing to hospitality.

At a glance

Name	Lydia; perhaps "the Lydian woman"
Home city	Thyatira, in the Roman province of Asia (Acts 16:14)
Lived in	Philippi, a Roman colony in Macedonia (Acts 16:12, 15)
Work	"A seller of purple," costly dye or cloth (Acts 16:14)
Faith	She "worshipped God" before she heard Paul (Acts 16:14)
When	c. AD 49–50, on Paul's second journey
Key people	Paul, Silas, and the writer of Acts ("we," Acts 16:13)
New Testament	Named only in Acts 16:14 and 16:40

"And a certain woman named Lydia, a seller of purple, of the city of Thyatira, which worshipped God, heard us: whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul."

Acts 16:14, KJV

The life of Lydia

Dates are approximate (AD). Lydia's story takes place during Paul's second journey, c. AD 49–52. Acts records only a few days of her life.

Before Paul came	● From Thyatira to Philippi Lydia, originally from Thyatira, has a house in Philippi and trades in purple. She already worships the God of Israel. <i>Acts 16:14–15</i>
c. AD 49–50 <i>Troas</i>	● A call to Macedonia Paul sees a vision of a man of Macedonia praying, "Come over into Macedonia, and help us." The team sails for Europe and reaches Philippi. <i>Acts 16:9–12</i>
c. AD 49–50 <i>A sabbath by the river</i>	● She listens Outside the city, by a river "where prayer was wont to be made," women gather. Paul and his companions sit down and speak to them, and Lydia listens. <i>Acts 16:13–14</i>
The same season	● Heart opened, household baptized The Lord opens Lydia's heart to take in Paul's message. She and her household are baptized. <i>Acts 16:14–15</i>
During their stay	● Opens her home She urges the travelers, "If ye have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come into my house, and abide there." They accept. <i>Acts 16:15</i>
After the prison	● Hosts the church Freed from prison, Paul and Silas go to Lydia's house, see the believers, comfort them, and leave the city. <i>Acts 16:40</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Acts does not say whether Lydia was married, widowed or single. That she had her own house and household suggests she was its head, but Scripture gives no more detail.

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- 1 Ran a business.** She sold purple, a trade in luxury goods, far from her home city. *Acts 16:14*
 - 2 Worshipped God.** Before meeting Paul, she already worshipped the God of Israel. *Acts 16:14*
 - 3 Kept the place of prayer.** She was among the women who met by the river on the sabbath. *Acts 16:13*
 - 4 Listened.** She "heard us," and "attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul." *Acts 16:14*
 - 5 Was baptized with her household.** She took her stand with Christ publicly, and her household joined her. *Acts 16:15*
 - 6 Offered hospitality.** She pressed the travelers to stay with her until they agreed: "And she constrained us." *Acts 16:15*
 - 7 Hosted the young church.** After the prison, the believers were gathered at her house. *Acts 16:40*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Lydia is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 26:1	Blue, purple and scarlet in the tabernacle
Echo: Proverbs 31:24	The capable woman "maketh fine linen, and selleth it"
Echo: Genesis 18:1–8	Abraham hurries to welcome strangers

New Testament

Acts 16:12–15	She hears, believes, is baptized, opens her home
Acts 16:40	Paul and Silas return to her house
Philippians 1:3–5	"Fellowship in the gospel from the first day"
Revelation 2:18–29	Christ's letter to Thyatira, her home city
Echo: Luke 24:45	Jesus opens the disciples' understanding

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Where was Lydia, and what was she doing, when she first heard Paul (Acts 16:13–14)?
2. *Understand:* Lydia listened, and "the Lord opened" her heart (Acts 16:14). How do those two work together?
3. *Apply:* How could you use your home or table for someone this month?
4. *Apply:* How might your job or skills serve God's people?

Group notes